Pulong Arpa

Pulong Arpa (1900s–1980s), also spelled *Pullong*, was a Filipino military officer, diplomat, and public servant from the Sulu Archipelago. He is best remembered as the **First Filipino and First Bangsamoro Ambassador to Egypt**, serving from 1957 to 1963. A Sama Muslim from Sulu, Arpa broke new ground in a foreign service that had historically been the preserve of Christian elites from Luzon and the Visayas. His career spanned two starkly different worlds: the brutal jungles of a World War II guerrilla campaign, and the sophisticated chambers of Cold War-era Arab diplomacy.

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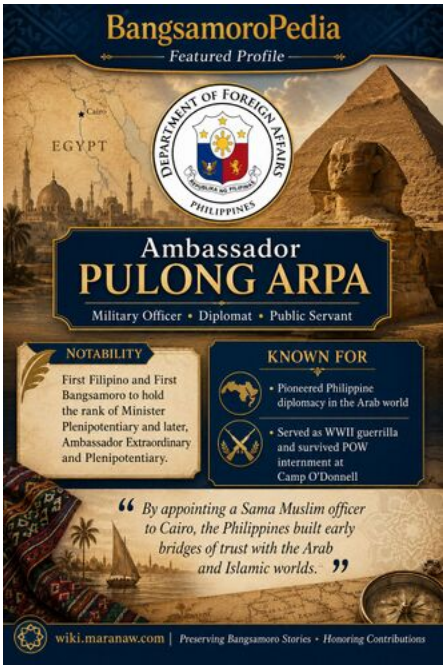
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BACKGROUND

Arpa was born into the Sulu Archipelago, deep in the maritime heartland of Muslim Mindanao. He came from the Sama people, a seafaring ethnolinguistic group native to the islands and coastal waters of Sulu, historically underrepresented in national leadership. His rise to prominence was a milestone not just for himself, but for an entire community that had long lived on the margins of Philippine state power.

His family roots ran deep into the region's ruling and religious classes. His father, Imam Arpa of Siasi, Sulu, was a respected religious leader and community figure. His mother, Tan Lu Liyan (also known as Liyudayang), connected him through the maternal line to Datu Piang, the legendary Maguindanaoan chieftain who dominated the political landscape of the late Spanish and early American colonial

PULONG ARPA



Full Name

Pulong Arpa (also spelled Pullong)

Born

1900s, Sulu Archipelago, Philippines

Died

1980s

Ethnic Group

Sama (Sulu Archipelago)

periods. Through her father, Tan Sing Lian, Arpa also belonged to a prominent Chinese-Tausug merchant lineage with trading networks stretching across the Sulu and Celebes Seas.

EDUCATION

Arpa pursued a rigorous military education, eventually graduating from the Philippine Military Academy (PMA). His class included figures who would go on to define the early Armed Forces of the Philippines, among them Colonel Edwin Andrews, the decorated officer after whom Edwin Andrews Air Base in Zamboanga City was later named.

CAREER

Military Service and World War II

When Japanese forces swept across the Philippine archipelago in 1941, Arpa was already a commissioned officer. Rather than surrender, he joined the armed resistance. He commanded the **1st Battalion of the 75th Provisional Infantry Regiment** under the Negros Force, leading Filipino guerrillas in the dense jungles of Negros Island in campaigns to defend key positions and disrupt enemy supply lines.

His service came at a terrible cost. When organized American-Filipino resistance collapsed, Arpa was captured. He was interned at the notorious **Camp O'Donnell** in Capas, Tarlac, the harrowing final destination of the Bataan Death March survivors. He endured the brutal conditions of the camp and survived. When the Philippines was liberated, he returned to active military duty and eventually retired with the rank of **Colonel**.

Diplomatic Career

After Philippine independence in 1946, the national government sought capable, culturally credible representatives for a young republic navigating the Cold War. President Carlos P. Garcia looked beyond the usual circles of the foreign service and found Pulong Arpa.

On **April 12, 1957**, President Garcia administered Arpa's oath of office, appointing him **Minister Plenipotentiary to Egypt**. It was a historic first: Arpa became the **first Filipino Muslim ever appointed to the foreign service with the rank of**

Parents

Imam Arpa of Siasi, Sulu; Tan Lu Liyan (Liyudayang)

Notable Relative

Datu Piang of Maguindanao (grand-uncle, maternal side)

Military Rank

Colonel (Retired), Armed Forces of the Philippines

Military Education

Philippine Military Academy (PMA)

WWII Command

1st Battalion, 75th Provisional Infantry Regiment, Negros Force

Diplomatic Posts

Minister Plenipotentiary to Egypt (1957); Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary to Egypt and Syria (1960–1963)

Appointed By

President Carlos P. Garcia

Minister. Cairo, the intellectual and cultural heart of the Arab world, was where the Philippines would now plant its diplomatic flag in the region.

As the geopolitical significance of the Middle East grew through the late 1950s, so did the scope of Arpa's mission. In **1960**, the Philippine government elevated the legation to a full-scale embassy, and Arpa was promoted to the rank of **Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary**. That same year, President Garcia concurrently appointed him the **first official Philippine Ambassador to Syria**, at a time when Egypt and Syria had merged to form the United Arab Republic (UAR). Even after Syria broke away from the UAR following a 1961 coup, Arpa's Cairo mission retained diplomatic jurisdiction over Syrian affairs, effectively laying the institutional groundwork for the future Embassy of the Philippines in Damascus.

NOTABILITY

First Filipino and First Bangsamoro Ambassador to Egypt; first Filipino Muslim to hold the rank of Minister Plenipotentiary in the Philippine foreign service

KNOWN FOR

Pioneering Philippine diplomacy in the Arab world; establishing the only Philippine diplomatic mission in the Arab and African regions from 1957 to the mid-1970s; WWII guerrilla service and POW survival at Camp O'Donnell

PULL QUOTE

"By deploying a proud Sama Muslim officer to Cairo, the Philippines built early bridges of trust with the Arab and Islamic worlds that would define its foreign policy for decades."

INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

Arpa's mission in Cairo was not just a posting. It was the foundation of Philippine diplomacy across an entire region. From 1957 until the mid-1970s, the embassy he established stood as the **only Philippine diplomatic mission in the entire Arab and African regions**. The communication channels, cultural exchanges, and early diplomatic treaties he helped initiate shaped how the Philippine government would relate to Islamic nations for generations, including how it would eventually approach the question of Muslim Mindanao in its foreign policy.

His appointment was also a statement, made in policy rather than words, that the Philippines recognized its Muslim citizens as part of its national identity, not just its internal affairs.

LEGACY

Arpa is remembered as a pioneer on two fronts. In the military, he was a combat soldier who survived one of the war's most brutal prison camps and came out of it still committed to service. In diplomacy, he built something that outlasted his tenure: a framework for Philippine engagement with the Arab world that his successors would inherit and expand.

For the Bangsamoro people, his life represents an early proof of what was possible. A Sama Muslim from Sulu, with no access to the inherited advantages that defined the Manila-centric foreign service, rose to represent the Philippine republic at the highest diplomatic level in the Arab world. That story still carries weight.

Those who knew him described a man of many dimensions: a disciplined military officer, a skilled diplomat, an avid swimmer and sports enthusiast in his younger years, and in his final decades, an elder statesman and irreplaceable keeper of Sulu's history.

RECOGNITION

- First Filipino Muslim appointed to the foreign service with the rank of Minister (1957)
- First Filipino and First Bangsamoro Ambassador to Egypt (1957–1963)
- First Philippine Ambassador to Syria (1960)
- Founding builder of the Philippine diplomatic presence in the Arab and African worlds

SEE ALSO

- Bangsamoro people
- Sama people of Sulu
- Datu Piang
- Philippine Military Academy
- Camp O'Donnell
- Carlos P. Garcia
- Embassy of the Philippines in Cairo
- Embassy of the Philippines in Damascus
- Bataan Death March
- United Arab Republic

REFERENCES

1. Sources referenced in the preparation of this article include institutional records, family-sourced biographical notes, and verified secondary accounts of Philippine diplomatic and military history.

EXTERNAL LINKS

- BangsamoroPedia — wiki.maranaw.com (https://wiki.maranaw.com)

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